

Ending the hiatus: Virat Kohli made a rare appearance at the Ranji Trophy, his first since 2012, and shared his valuable experiences with the Delhi team and support staff. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR



the ranks. "There is an old connection between us, and we were reminiscing about those memories. A few players asked Virat for advice on what it takes to play for India. His emphasis was on performance and fitness. He also made jokes and kept the atmosphere light. By the end, for the others, it didn't feel like it was Virat. Initially, a few of the boys were shy and nervous about his presence, but I had told them not to worry," Bhati added.

When the game finished, Kohli signed autographs, posed for photos, and gave away some of his bats and other equipment to whoever asked.

"He gave many of them something from his kit bag — some received bats, while one player got his helmet. A few had their bats signed by him," Bhati said.

Test of loyalties

The last two rounds of the Ranji Trophy group stage witnessed a remarkable surge in attendance at various venues, thanks to the return of several Indian first-team stars to the domestic circuit after years away.

The chants of "Mumbaicha raja" for Rohit Sharma at Mumbai's BKC Stadium and the seemingly endless

queue outside the Kotla in the early hours to catch a glimpse of Kohli have been well documented.

Away from the frenzy of these metropolitan hubs, in the serene surroundings of the VCA Stadium in Civil Lines, Nagpur, a sizeable crowd had gathered to watch *Miya Bhai* Mohammed Siraj in action.

Over the four days of play, what unfolded in the stadium could reflect the average Indian cricket fan's paradoxical loyalties. Siraj, a perennial crowd favourite thanks to his

charisma, was greeted with enthusiasm as he bowled a miserly eight-over spell, conceding just six runs in the first innings on day one.

The Nagpur crowd roared with cheers and whistles every time Siraj fielded near the boundary, right under the only stand open to spectators. Even his misfields were met with applause! Ever the entertainer, Siraj acknowledged the support with a few claps and took time to sign and return some memorabilia.

However, when all-rounder Harsh Dubey launched a counter-attack with wickets tumbling around him, the very same crowd swiftly switched allegiances, celebrating each boundary struck off their morning's hero without hesitation.

On the fourth morning, Siraj responded in kind, smashing a few sixes as Vidarbha dismantled the visitor's batting line-up. The moment he walked in, he gestured towards Vidarbha captain Akshay Wadkar to bring mid-on and mid-off up.

"When I walked in, Karun Nair remarked that I couldn't slog the ball. So, I asked them to push the field up so I could prove otherwise," Siraj revealed with a grin during the post-match chat. "Karun was my India A skipper, and we share a great understanding."

Fan-favourite: Mohammed Siraj was greeted with enthusiasm as he bowled a miserly eight-over spell, conceding just six runs. PTI

